

🔍 A SPOTTER'S GUIDE FOR CURIOUS KIDS

Birds by the Water

Seven feathered friends we spotted by the water in Chalakudy, Kerala — and the amazing things they can do.



👁️ Look closely. Listen carefully. Every bird has a secret!

How to be a Bird Detective

Every bird in this book has its own page. On each one you'll find little clue-cards to help you spot it in real life. Here is what they mean:

 **How big?** How large the bird is next to things you know.

 **Favourite food** What lands on its dinner plate.

 **My call** The sound to listen for.

 **Where to look** The best place to find it.

 **Superpower** The one incredible thing it can do.

3 Golden Rules of Bird-Spotting

1. **Be a statue.** Birds fly off if you rush. Move slowly and stay quiet.
2. **Use your ears.** You will often hear a bird long before you see it.
3. **Look for clues.** Colour, beak shape and tail help you tell who's who.

Turn the page and meet bird number one →

01

The Bug-Snatcher

Green Bee-eater

Merops orientalis



Meet the little jewel of the riverbank! This shiny green bird has a rusty-orange cap, a smart black eye-mask and two long thread-like feathers trailing from its tail. It loves to sit very still on a wire, then zoom out like a tiny arrow to grab a flying insect and swoosh right back.



HOW BIG?

About as long as a pencil (with 2 extra tail wires!)



FAVOURITE FOOD

Bees, wasps and dragonflies — snapped up in mid-air



MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE

A soft rolling "tree-tree-tree" trill



WHERE TO LOOK

Farm fences, wires and reeds near ponds and rivers



SUPERPOWER! Catches a bee while flying, then bonks it on a branch to knock the sting off before eating!

👁️ **Spot me by: my shiny green coat and long tail streamers.**

02

The Cheeky Chatterbox

Common Myna

Acridotheres tristis

Say hello to one of the boldest birds around. The myna has a chocolate-brown body, a glossy black head, and bright yellow goggles of bare skin around its eyes to match its yellow beak and legs. When it flies you'll see a flash of white on its wings. Clever, curious and always up for a chat.

**HOW BIG?**

About as big as your open hand and wrist

**FAVOURITE FOOD**

Almost anything — insects, fruit, seeds and crumbs

**MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE**

A chatty mix of whistles, gurgles and copied sounds

**WHERE TO LOOK**

Everywhere near people — gardens, streets, parks and farms



SUPERPOWER! Super smart! It can copy other birds' songs and even a few human words, and struts around like it owns the place.

👁 **Spot me by: my yellow eye-patch, beak and legs.**

03

The Whiskered Fruit-Muncher

White-cheeked Barbet

Psilopogon viridis

This green bird has a streaky brown-and-white face, a white eyebrow, a matching cheek stripe, and funny little whiskers (called bristles) around its beak. Here it is caught in the rain, looking damp and grumpy in one photo and fluffing dry in the other! Because it eats so much fruit, it helps plant new trees by dropping seeds far and wide.

**HOW BIG?**

A little smaller than the myna

**FAVOURITE FOOD**

Juicy fruit like figs and papaya — plus a few insects

**MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE**

A loud, tireless "kut-roo... kut-roo..." all day long

**WHERE TO LOOK**

Only in South India's Western Ghats — gardens and fruit trees



SUPERPOWER! A feathered carpenter! It uses its beak to chisel its own round nest-hole into a tree trunk.

👁 **Spot me by: my white cheek stripe and whiskery beak.**

04

The Fearless King Crow

Black Drongo

Dicrurus macrocercus

Glossy blue-black from beak to tail, the drongo is famous for its deep fish-tail and its brave heart. People call it the "King Crow" because it bosses birds ten times its size. It loves to ride on grazing cattle, snapping up the insects the animals stir up in the grass. Here, three of them share a wire above the water.

**HOW BIG?**

Sleek and slim, with a long forked tail

**FAVOURITE FOOD**

Insects — grasshoppers, moths and dragonflies caught in flight

**MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE**

Sharp whistles and clever copies of other birds' calls

**WHERE TO LOOK**

Open fields — often perched on wires, fences or a cow's back



SUPERPOWER! Tiny but fearless! It will chase away crows, hawks and even eagles that come too close to its nest.

👁 **Spot me by: my forked fish-tail and fearless attitude.**

05

The Hovering Fisher

Pied Kingfisher

Ceryle rudis

This is the only kingfisher dressed just in black and white — speckled all over like a splash of ink, with a spiky little crest and a big dagger beak. It is one of the very few birds in the world that can truly hover, staying still in the sky before its lightning dive. Watch the water and you might catch the splash!

**HOW BIG?**

About the length of a school ruler

**FAVOURITE FOOD**

Fish, fish and more fish (plus a few tadpoles)

**MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE**

A sharp, chirpy "chirruk-chirruk" whistle

**WHERE TO LOOK**

Above lakes, rivers and ponds, all across Africa and Asia



SUPERPOWER! It can hover in one spot in mid-air, wings buzzing, then dive like a dart to spear a fish underwater!

👁 **Spot me by: my black-and-white spots and pointy crest.**

06

The Rainbow Hunter

White-throated Kingfisher

Halcyon smyrnensis

A burst of colour! This kingfisher has a chocolate-brown head and belly, a snowy-white throat and chest, a huge coral-red beak, and dazzling turquoise-blue wings that flash like sapphires in the sun. Don't let the name fool you — it is happy to hunt bugs and lizards nowhere near a river at all.

**HOW BIG?**

About the length of a school ruler

**FAVOURITE FOOD**

Not just fish! Also lizards, frogs, bugs and even small snakes

**MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE**

A loud, laughing "kili-li-li-li" that carries a long way

**WHERE TO LOOK**

Gardens, farms and wires almost anywhere in India



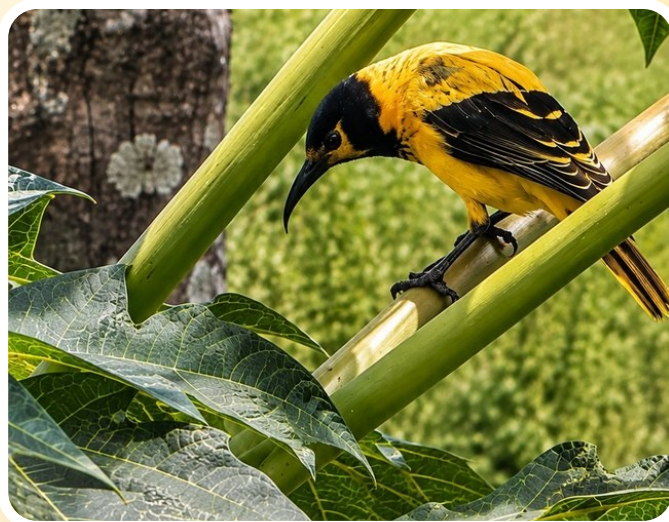
SUPERPOWER! A brave mini-hunter that often catches its dinner far away from any water, out in dry fields and gardens.

👁️ **Spot me by: my white throat and bright red beak.**

07

The Hidden Gold

Black-hooded Oriole

Oriolus xanthornus

Here is the showstopper of the bunch. The oriole wears a glossy black hood over a body of pure sunshine-yellow, with black-and-yellow wings and a pinkish, gently curved beak that is just right for poking into figs. These birds are shy singers that stay tucked away high in the canopy, dressed to blend into the dappled leaves — which makes catching a good look at one a real treat.

**HOW BIG?**

About your hand-and-forearm long (roughly 24 cm)

**FAVOURITE FOOD**

Fruit — especially figs — plus a few juicy insects

**MY CALL SOUNDS LIKE**

A rich, flute-like whistle: "wela-wela-weeoo"

**WHERE TO LOOK**

High in the leafy treetops of gardens and woodlands



SUPERPOWER! A champion of hide-and-seek! Its golden-and-black feathers melt into sunlit leaves, so you'll often hear it long before you ever see it.

👁️ **Spot me by: my black hood and glowing golden body.**

Your Spotting Checklist

Been outside exploring? Tick a box each time you spot one of our birds in the wild. Can you find all seven?

- ☐ **01 Green Bee-eater** The Bug-Snatcher
- ☐ **02 Common Myna** The Cheeky Chatterbox
- ☐ **03 White-cheeked Barbet** The Whiskered Fruit-Muncher
- ☐ **04 Black Drongo** The Fearless King Crow
- ☐ **05 Pied Kingfisher** The Hovering Fisher
- ☐ **06 White-throated Kingfisher** The Rainbow Hunter
- ☐ **07 Black-hooded Oriole** The Hidden Gold



Found every single one? You are officially a **Junior Bird Detective!**

Now go and find a bird that is NOT in this book — there are thousands more waiting.